autonomy, all built from the ground up right here in India.

Despite these leaps, India's ability to absorb innovation hasn't quite kept pace with its ability to generate it. "Our buying processes are built for commoditized technology. They're not built for innovative technology induction," Mehta says, pointing to a systemic bottleneck. The product may be cutting-edge, demonstrated in real-world contexts. But without procurement agility, those innovations can languish.

This is particularly vexing in a sector like drones, where government consumption dwarfs all else. "Unless you look at logistics, it is going to be heavily dominated by government use," Mehta says. Unlike the U.S., where infrastructure players or private energy companies might be customers, Indian drone tech is still predominantly geared toward public sector deployment.

Yet the landscape is shifting. "Perhaps one of the first inducted heterogeneous swarms was inducted in India by the government," Mehta notes. ideaForge also delivered the country's first high-altitude vertical takeoff and landing drone with significant performance headroom. These aren't trivial checkboxes; they're strategic capabilities for mission critical tasks.

While ISR (intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance) remains the company's bread and butter, Mehta is candid about the direction the sector is heading. "With what we saw in Operation Z, the end effect-causing capability or the kinetic capability is also going to be critically important for at least any defense mission," he says. This includes loitering munitions and other forms of kinetic payload delivery. "These are important capabilities that will form a part of our customer's arsenal," he adds.

ideaForge has also found itself at the center of India's evolving civic-tech narrative. From mapping 660,000 Indian villages under the government's SVAMITVA scheme, to inspecting thermal power plants and critical infrastructure, the company's drones are

becoming an everyday tool of statecraft.

And the performance keeps climbing. "On one of our quadcopters, we were delivering 20-30% better performance than the best capability we were aware of globally at that time," Mehta says, referring to even their 2010-era platforms. It's a standard they've held to. Their lightweight systems now deliver more flight time, better endurance, and higher reliability than most rivals.

The secret, according to Mehta, is to keep the outcome in mind. "Nobody wants to fly a drone if it's a daily job. They want to absorb the outcome. And that's what we enable," he says. For ideaForge, performance isn't just a metric but a mission – as cliched as it sounds.

In many ways, ideaForge is a test case for what it means to build deep tech in India. The code isn't copied. The designs aren't reverse-engineered. The flight time specs don't lie. "We don't just try to make the best drones in India. We always aim and attempt to make the best drones in the world," Mehta reiterates with some well-deserved pride.

If there's one thing to take away from ideaForge's journey, it's this: India's drone revolution didn't start with a government policy or a foreign MOU. It started with a bunch of engineers in 2004, chasing curiosity, writing their own code, and eventually, rewriting the rules of engagement. In a space increasingly defined by off-the-shelf imports and vendor lock-in, ideaForge stands as a quietly radical proposition, if you think about it. An alien concept almost. That India doesn't just deserve great technology – it can build it, too.

India's evolving UAV journey

Believe it or not, before ideaForge drones were deployed by defence forces, they had an unlikely first flight on Bollywood's silver screen. "One of the earliest prototypes of ours was used in the movie 3 Idiots," recalls Ankit Mehta. "So we, in a way, seeded this technology in the minds of our common population."

It's not the only time Mehta sees ideaForge shaping public perception from behind the scenes. Despite headlines around drone deliveries or military exercises, he believes the everyday Indian remains largely unaware of how embedded drones already are. "Unless a Swiggy or Zomato delivery happens through a drone, people will not acknowledge that this is happening."

He's also quick to draw a parallel of drones with another modern utility, the CCTV. "They've become an augmented layer of security in public spaces. Drones are on a similar path – becoming integral to physical infrastructure and governance."

And while many believe Indian innovation lags in execution, Mehta offers a more nuanced take. "What we miss in India is not the ability to create best-in-class technology. It's our ability to absorb innovation as aggressively as the West does."